MAEC | Consortium for Eng
Families Across Ma

Centering Family Voices Across Maine's Public Schools

Insights from the 2024-2025 Maine Family Engagement Needs Assessment (MEFENA)

MAEC

Introduction

Families across Maine are deeply engaged in their children's education, but the systems meant to support them can often fall short of meeting their needs. This StoryMap uses data and direct quotes from families to tell a fuller story of the barriers, bright spots, and opportunities that emerged from the Maine Family Engagement Needs assessment (MEFENA).

Maine's rural geography, infrastructure, and localized school governance, shape how families experience and interact with schools. Because local control plays such a strong role in shaping family engagement across the state, this StoryMap includes disaggregated data by county and rurality wherever possible to

reflect these regional differences and help readers interpret the findings within their community context.

While MEFENA was not designed to evaluate every aspect of the education system, it offers valuable insight into key areas that matter most to families: communication, access to enrichment and learning tools, support for basic needs, and relationships with school staff.

Each section of the StoryMap lifts what families reported most often and most urgently. Quotes are drawn directly from survey responses, and data visuals help illustrate the patterns that emerged. Presenting the information through a StoryMap makes family engagement more accessible, equitable, and tangible for schools, districts, and community partners.

This StoryMap is organized thematically. It begins with families' access to learning resources and school communication, then moves through enrichment opportunities, non-academic needs, and experiences with school culture and systems of support. Later sections explore trends by race, region, and county. Each section includes direct quotes, summary data visuals, and reflections on both bright spots and opportunities for growth.

Key themes:

- Communication systems that are informative, inclusive, and timely.
- Learning resources that are accessible both at home and at school.
- Enrichment and support programs that match families' real needs.
- Strong, respectful relationships with school staff.
- Systemic barriers that limit access, especially in rural communities.

About the Survey

The Maine Family Engagement Needs Assessment (MEFENA) aimed to elevate the voices of families across the state. MAEC's Consortium for Engaging Families Across Maine (CEFAM) and the Maine Department of Education launched a statewide survey in Fall 2024 to learn how families experience school communication, access to learning resources, enrichment opportunities, and broader support systems.

The survey was available in English, Spanish, French, Portuguese, Somali, and Arabic, and reached a diverse sample of families across grade levels, counties, and racial backgrounds. After completing the survey, families were invited to enter their contact information for a chance to win a $50 Target gift card and indicate interest in a follow-up focus group. Of those who completed the form, 167 expressed interest in participating. CEFAM followed up with all interested individuals, offering two virtual session times to accommodate different schedules. A total of eight family members participated in these discussions, which focused on current family engagement efforts, challenges, and opportunities for improvement.

MAEC's Evaluation Norms

The StoryMap reflects the following norms by elevating direct family voice, highlighting both barriers and strengths, and focusing on system-level patterns rather than individual behaviors. Quotes are included throughout to center the lived experiences of families, and each section identifies opportunities for systemic improvement.

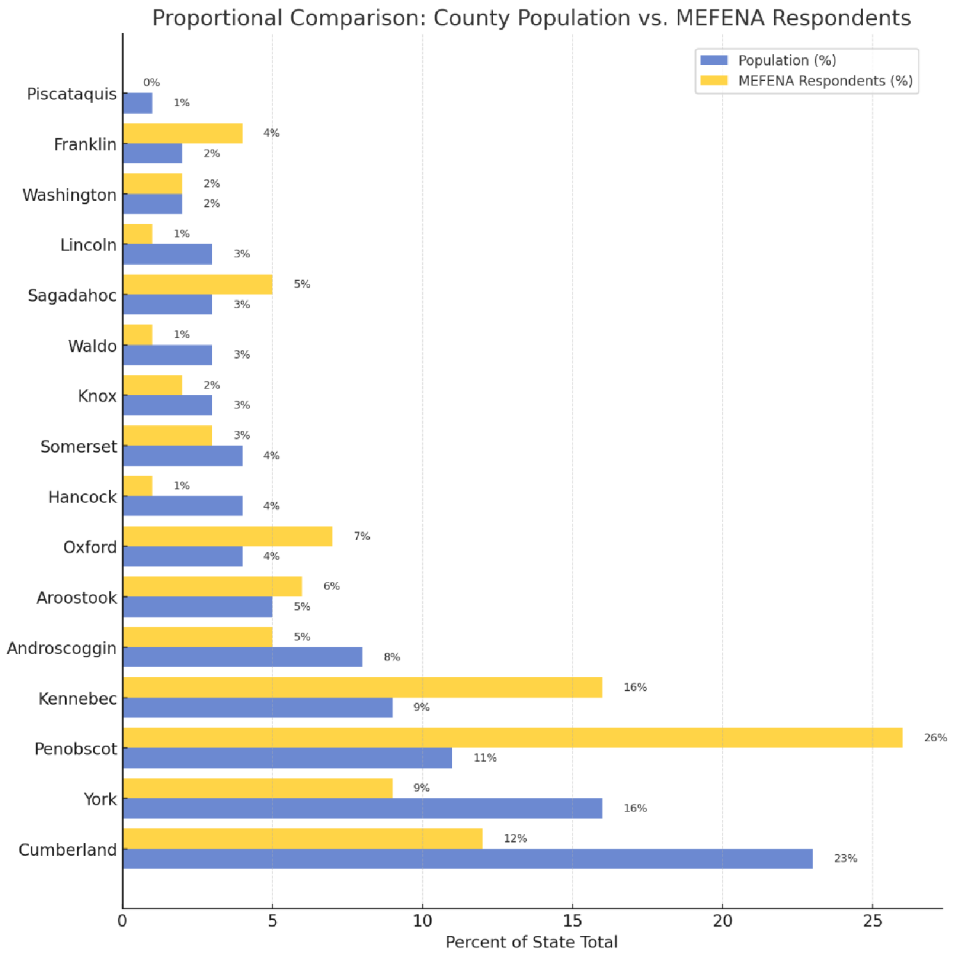
Note how these norms are applied as you go through each section: Where are families naming systemic gaps? What assets are already in place? How can schools and state leaders build on what's working while addressing inequities?

1. **See the humanity behind each data point**: Behind every percentage and data point, there are students, families, and staff with complex lived experiences and a collective hope for a stronger school system. It is important to consider the value of each voice as we focus on the larger picture.
2. **Focus on systems, not individuals:** Emphasize the importance of examining and addressing systemic factors that drive educational inequities, rather than attributing outcomes solely to individuals and their actions or characteristics.
3. **Acknowledge the bright spots:** Utilize an asset-based approach and showcase bright spots within the school community alongside, if not ahead of, areas of improvement. Bright spots not only affirm communities' strength, success, and pride but also serve as models for future changes, informing approaches to tackling new areas of improvement.
4. **Improvement over accountability:** Focus on progress and growth within educational institutions over punitive measures for underperformance. Encourage a supportive environment where the school community collaborates to identify areas for improvement and implement strategies to enhance outcomes.
5. **Long-term commitment over short-term implications:** Resist the pressure to make immediate changes that may be neither sustainable nor effective. Fostering equitable schools entails ongoing dedication to implementing promising practices, and sustainable progress requires nurturing a culture of continuous learning and development.

Maine Family Engagement Needs Assessment (MEFENA)

The MEFENA survey received 865 responses from family members/caregivers of school-aged children. Their experiences form the basis of this report. Their responses call for improving

systems to be more accessible, coordinated, and responsive to the realities of Maine families.



Who We Heard From

Participation came from 15 counties, with particularly strong representation from Kennebec and Penobscot. Most survey takers were family members/caregivers of Pre-K through 5th-grade students.

** Note: Piscataquis County had no survey respondents, which may reflect limited outreach, lower population density, or other barriers to accessing the survey.*

Most MEFENA survey respondents were family members/caregivers of children in elementary school (Pre-K to 5th grade):

- Pre-K: 20%
- Grades K-2: 44%
- Grades 3-5: 48%
- Grades 6-8: 29%
- Grades 9-12: 26%

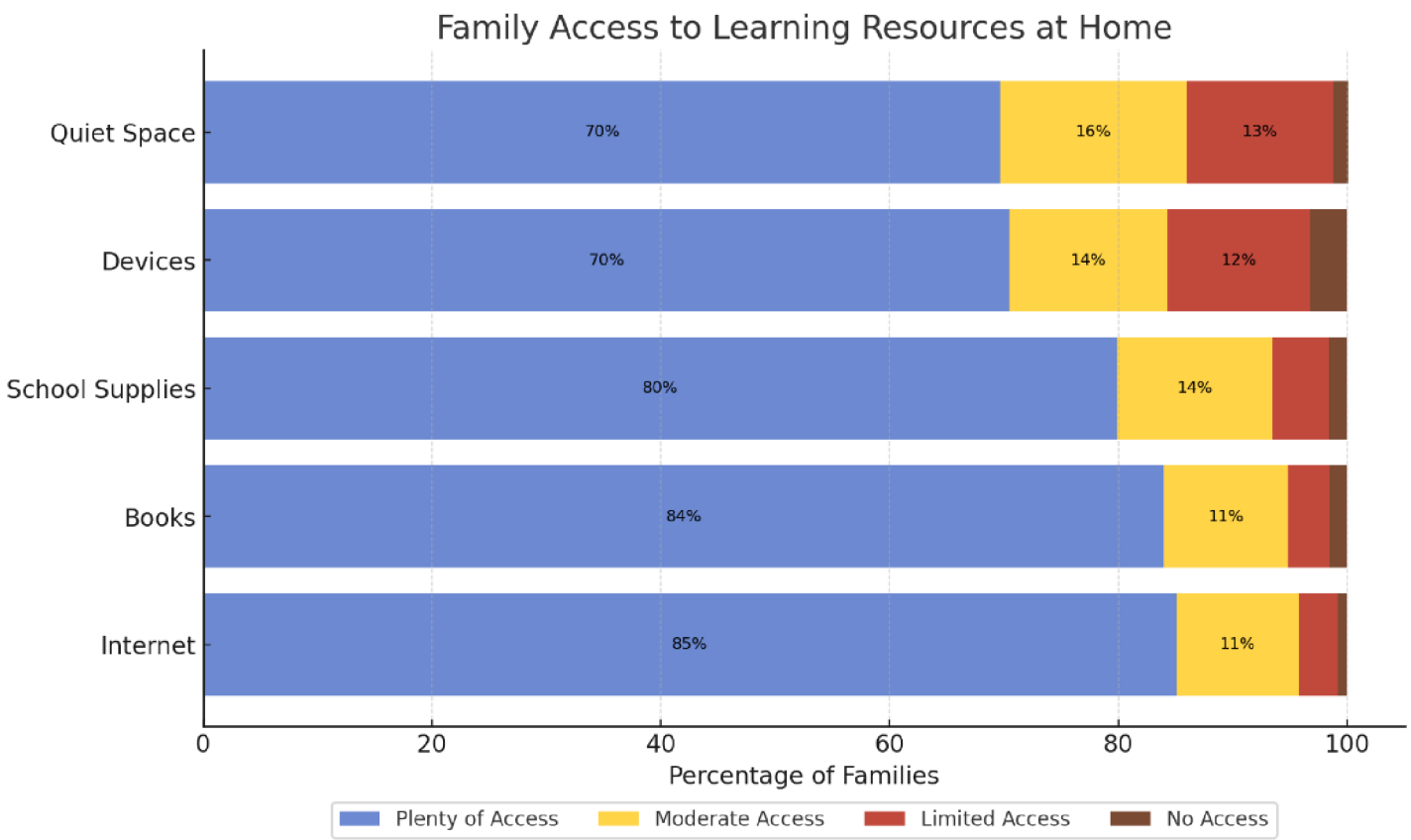
** Note: This question allowed families to select multiple grade levels, so percentages do not total 100%.*

As there were more families with younger children represented in the survey, many of the findings reflect their experiences more strongly than those of families with older students. However, Maine's statewide enrollment is more evenly distributed across grade levels (Maine DOE and NCES, 2023-24), which is an important context when interpreting findings related to enrichment, communication, and academic support.

Survey participation also varied by county and racial background, allowing for some disaggregated insight. For example, later sections highlight how families of color and those in rural regions reported greater challenges accessing learning resources and support services.

> "I want to be involved in my child's social and emotional growth as well as their academic growth."
>
> *- Oxford County Parent*

Learning at Home



Access to Learning Resources

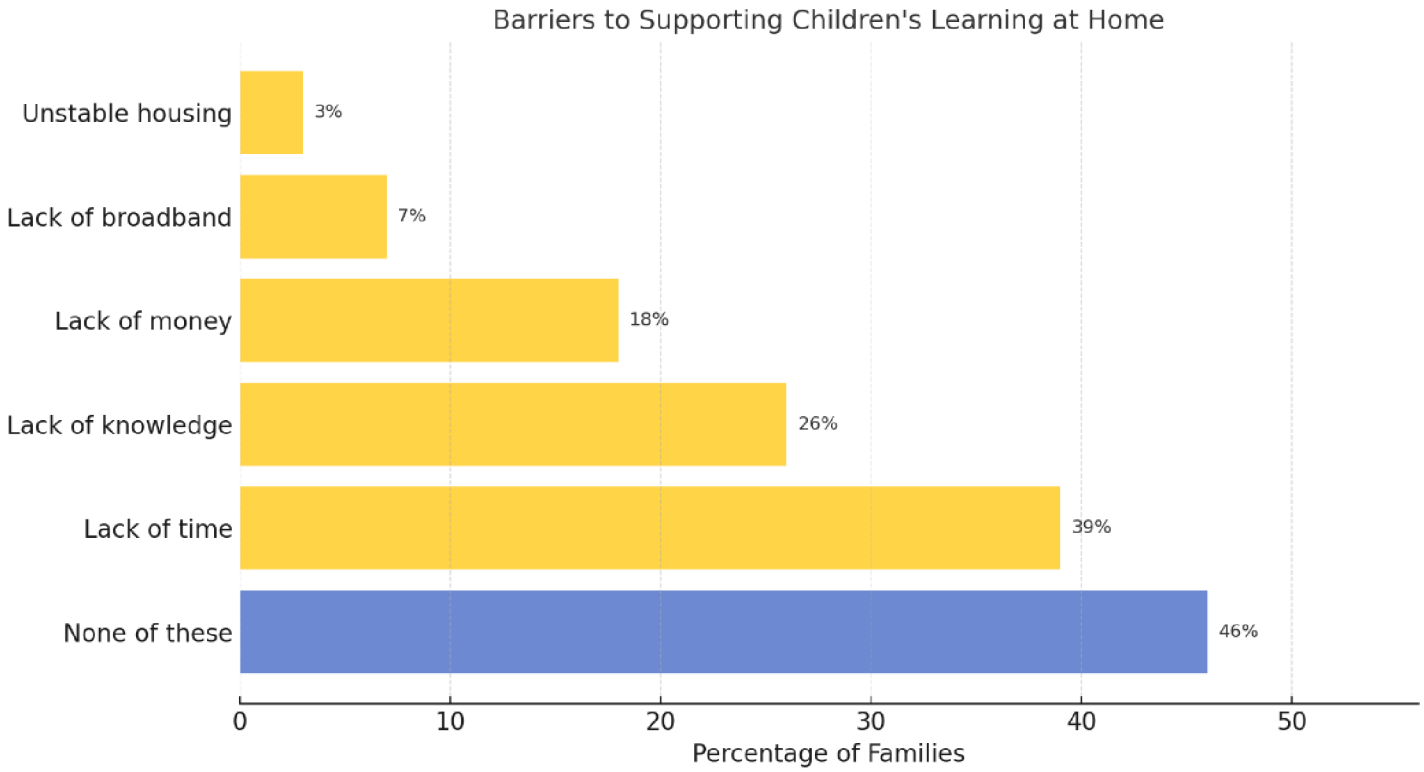
The following proportion of families reported having plenty of access to core tools for learning:

- Stable internet access (85%)
- Plenty of books at home (84%)
- Enough school supplies (80%)

These patterns suggest that while most families have the basic supplies and internet they need, lower access to quiet space and devices may reflect deeper structural challenges. Families living in shared housing, rural areas, or multigenerational homes may face greater difficulty creating stable learning environments.

Only 70% of families reported having plenty of access to devices or a quiet space for learning, the lowest among foundational resources. An additional 16% and 14% had moderate access, 13% and 12%

had limited access, and 1% and 4% reported no access at all. These foundational needs can significantly affect student outcomes, especially in remote or hybrid learning contexts.



Helping Children Learn at Home

Families most frequently identified the following barriers to supporting their child's learning:

- Lack of time (39%)
- Lack of confidence or knowledge (26%)
- Lack of money (18%)

These barriers reflect the complex trade-offs many families navigate, between work, caregiving, and limited time. The high rate of families reporting no barriers may indicate that when schools create inclusive, flexible systems, families are more equipped to support learning at home.

Still, 46% of families reported no barriers at all, a powerful reminder of families' capacity and commitment when systems make engagement possible.

Together, these findings point to a need for policies and practices that acknowledge the home environment as a key site of learning support. Addressing time, tools, and confidence requires collaboration across schools, families, and community partners.

> "I'd like for the school to give me more ideas about how to connect our home life to what they're learning at school. We don't have a ton of time in the evening to sit down and do worksheets together at this age (7), but we do have time in the car and at mealtimes and bedtime to talk, and it would be great to be extending their learning during those times."
>
> *- Cumberland County Parent*

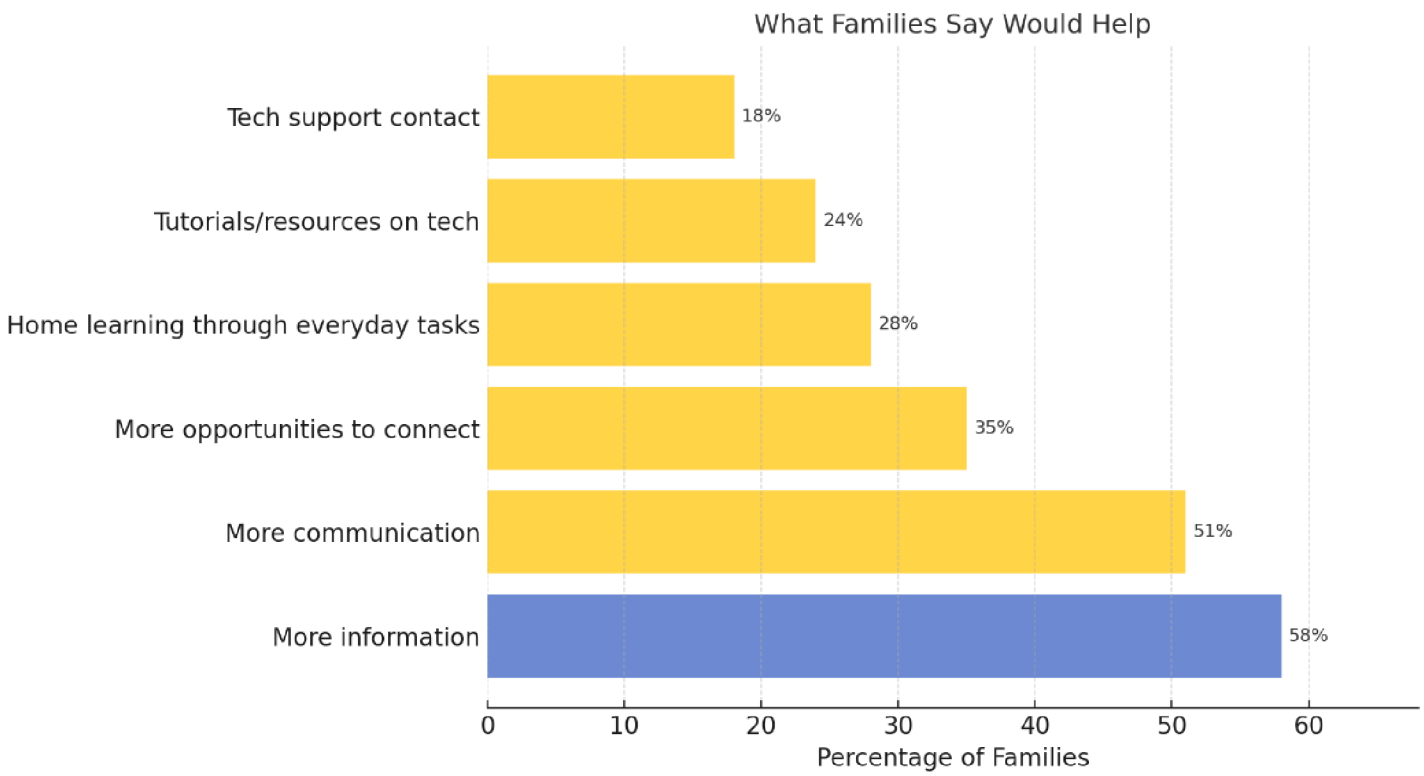
Bright Spots

- High levels of reported access to books and the internet.
- Nearly half of the families reported no barriers to home support.
- Clear desire from families to be involved in their child's education.

Opportunities for Growth

- Support equitable access to devices and quiet learning spaces.
- Support time-constrained families with flexible engagement options.
- Offer more resources and training to increase confidence in supporting learning.

Assessing Community Needs



School Communication and Engagement

Families identified several supports to help them better engage with their child's learning. The most common request was for more information from schools (58%), followed closely by more frequent communication (51%).

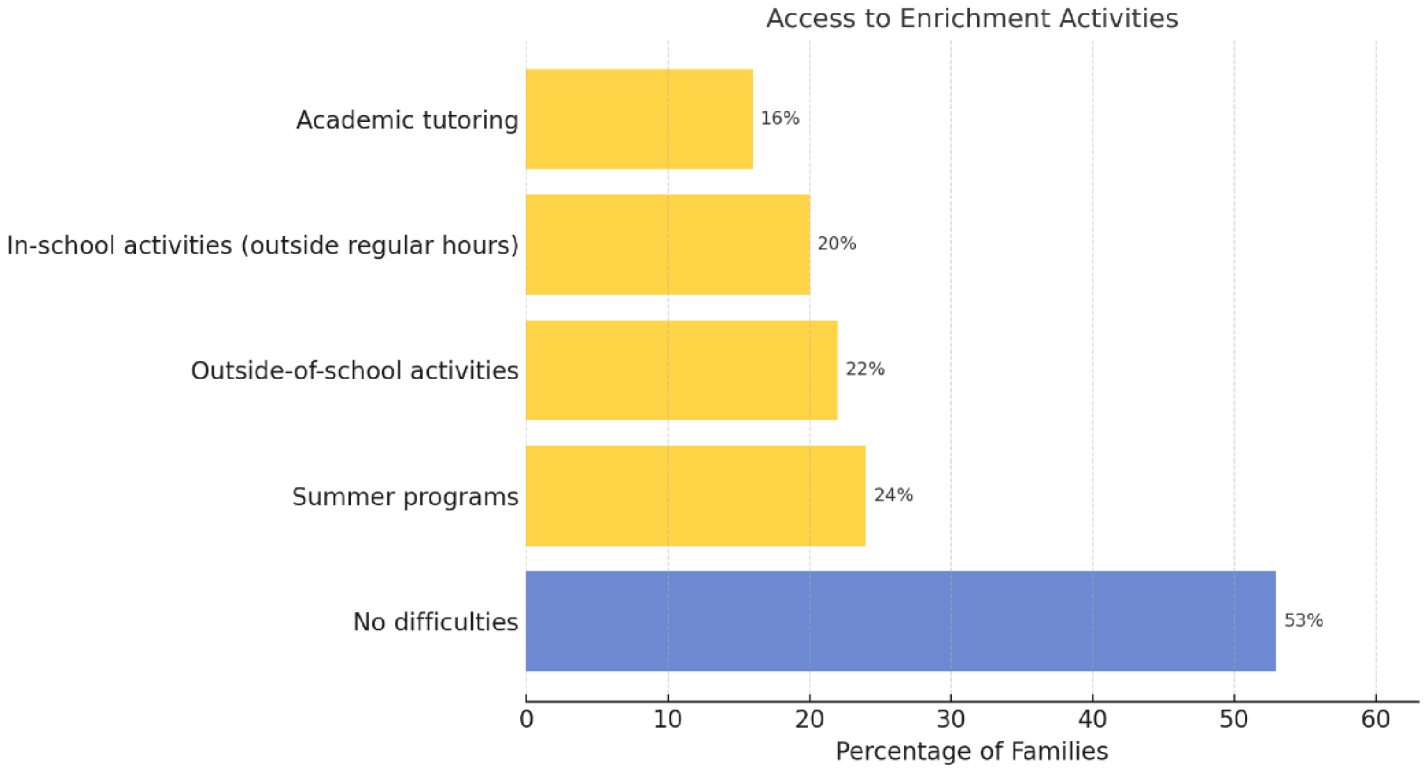
Other needs included:

- Opportunities to connect with other families (35%)
- Home learning ideas integrated into everyday tasks (28%)

These responses suggest that families don't just need more content; they need clearer, more accessible pathways for connection and support.

> "I want to know the staff and feel comfortable asking questions. I want to know how [my] child is doing academically and socially and have scheduled times to communicate instead of just 'reach out if you need us.'"
>
> *- Oxford County Parent*

> "In our district there are a lot of refugees, a lot of non-English speakers . . . . I think it would be helpful if there was some way for us to communicate with the other parents . . . I feel like that would get everyone more engaged."
>
> *–Focus Group Participant, Cumberland County Parent*



Enrichment as a Driver of Opportunity

When asked whether or not they had difficulty accessing enrichment opportunities, families reported mixed experiences. Approximately 53% said they had no difficulties accessing enrichment, a bright spot that points to successful programs and partnerships already in place.

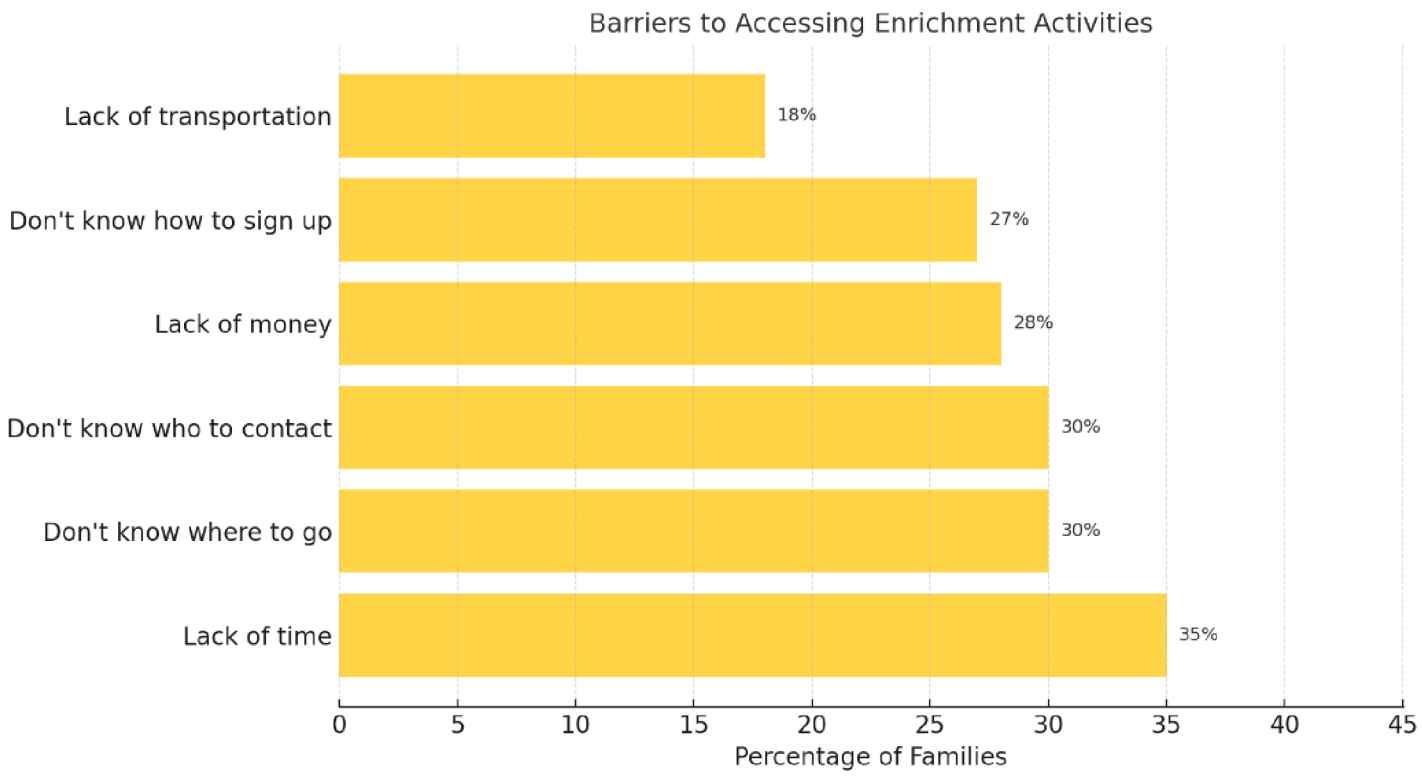
Still, many families reported having difficulties accessing specific types of enrichment:

- Summer programs (24%)
- Outside-of-school activities (22%)

These challenges may reflect not just availability, but how enrichment opportunities are communicated, scheduled, or supported by schools.

> "I would like for my children to have more school-based enrichment activities. Right now, the offerings from the elementary school are fee based. My daughter participates in a fall sport, but the fields are not located at the school. The school does not provide transportation for students to the practices and, as a result, it is very difficult and stressful for working parents to provide transportation, arrange carpools, etc. Also, changes to practice are often made or announced very last minute and this is extremely challenging. I think the schools lose sight of the fact that freshmen and sophomores do not have driver's licenses, whereas upperclassmen do. I also feel like we are a family that is caught in the middle. We make too much money to qualify for any tuition assistance or subsidies, but we don't make

> enough money to have disposable income to pay for extracurriculars."
>
> *-York County Parent*



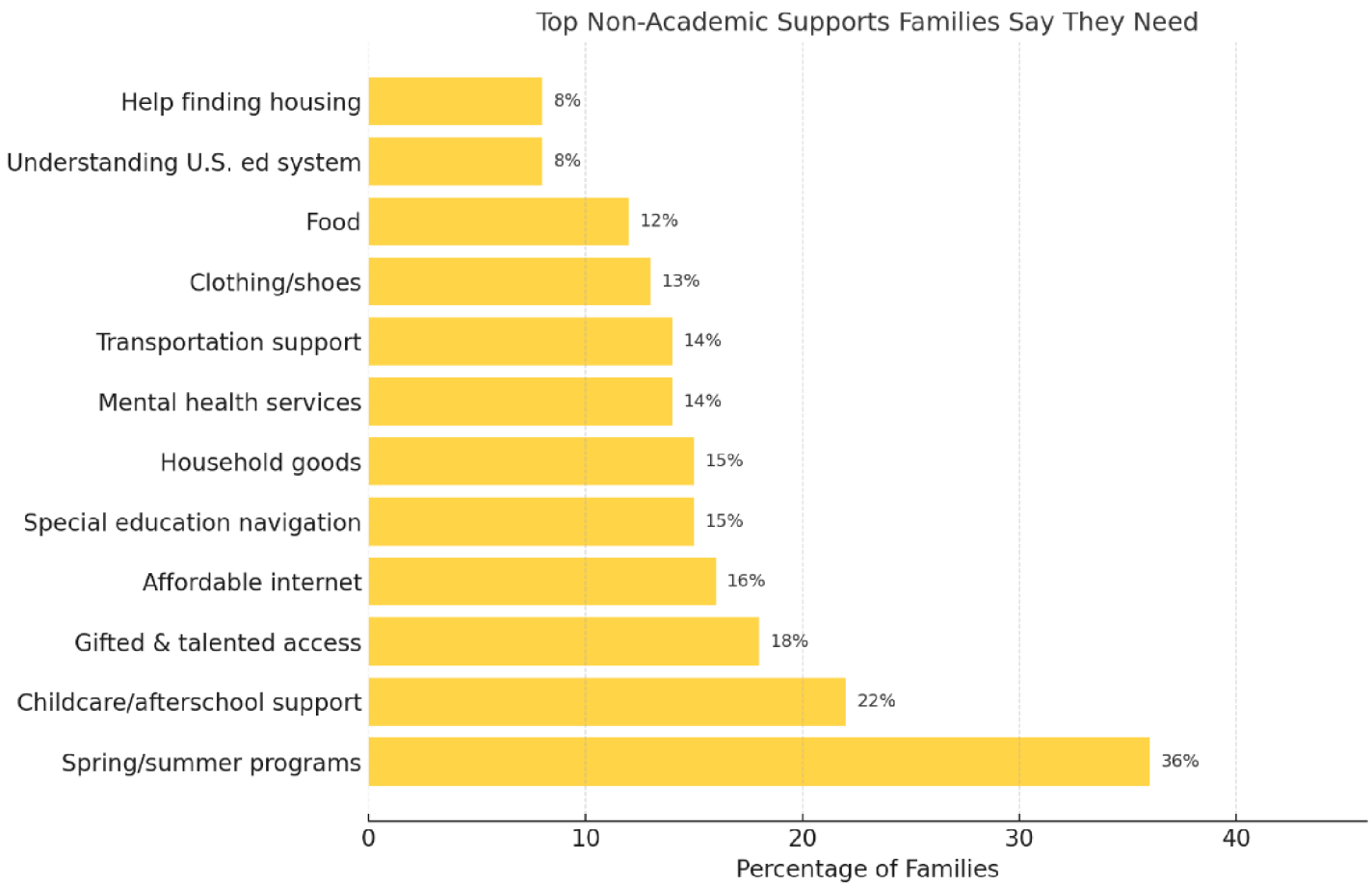
Barriers to Enrichment Access

Among families who reported challenges accessing enrichment, the most common barriers were not simply financial or logistical, but informational. Many families knew enrichment opportunities existed, but didn't know how to access them.

Top barriers included:

- Lack of time (35%)
- Not knowing where to go (30%)
- Not knowing who to contact (30%)

This signals a system where access may exist, but navigation is unclear, inconsistent, or inaccessible for many families.



Non-Academic Needs and Whole-Child Support

When asked what non-academic supports would help them most, families most commonly selected spring and summer programming (36%), affordable childcare or after-school support (22%), and access to gifted and talented programs (18%).

MAEC selected these categories during survey development, but they also surfaced in open-ended responses. Families shared how health, housing, transportation, and other challenges made it difficult to support learning at home. Several spoke candidly about the strain of managing basic needs while trying to stay engaged with school.

> "Single parenting is hard, getting tutoring outside of school is needed but difficult to find and transport to when I work FT."
>
> *- Penobscot County Parent*

Bright Spots

- The majority of families report that schools help with enrichment.
- Strong demand for communication and learning supports.
- Families expressed detailed insight into their own needs.

Opportunities for Growth

- Improve awareness of available school-based resources.
- Expand enrichment access beyond basic info sharing.
- Build systems to address whole-family needs alongside academics.

School Climate and Systems of Support

While the MEFENA survey primarily focused on family needs, access, and support, many participants shared reflections that speak to broader school conditions, such as staffing, communication, organization, and curriculum access. These insights are not a comprehensive evaluation of internal systems, but they offer valuable context for understanding the conditions that shape family engagement.

Navigating School Systems

In addition to challenges with access, many families shared concerns about how school opportunities are communicated and the difficulty in navigating available offerings. These issues, while not

always about availability, reflected frustration with systems that felt disjointed, unclear, or overly complex.

Families expressed frustration with how opportunities are communicated and accessed. Some learned about programs too late; others found school systems confusing or unresponsive. Some families recommended having a clear point of contact or a centralized system to help them navigate school offerings. These sentiments were also shared by family members in the focus groups, with some stating that an overwhelming amount of general emails from the schools made it difficult to identify important information.

> "Activities afterschool, on vacation and summer breaks, when they start, when are sign ups, how long the programs are, or athletic programs, there has not been any info given and no follow up on how to find them and where to find them."
>
> *- Kennebec County Parent*

> "I'm inundated with emails and figuring out which ones are important for me and my son . . . it gets to be exhausting…"
>
> *-Focus Group Participant, Cumberland County Parent*

Even when resources exist, families often lack the support needed to access or navigate them.

Bright Spots

- Families actively seek out enrichment opportunities.
- Many families are ready and willing to participate when informed early.

Opportunities for Growth

- Clarify program timelines and registration procedures.
- Create accessible communication channels with designated school contacts.

Mixed Experiences with School Culture

Open-ended responses revealed a wide range of experiences with school climate. Some families described welcoming, communicative school staff who took time to build relationships. Others described systems that felt difficult to access. Trust, consistency, and two-way communication were often missing in negative experiences, but were key in positive ones.

> "I would love more communication with teachers and schools. I often feel like I am 'bothering' the teacher when I ask questions and want to be more involved."
>
> *- Oxford County Parent*

> "So our school is really good. They use a text messaging system. They also have a daily newsletter. They have a monthly newsletter. Our alumni is really involved. So we get a lot of information that way. There's constant emails from the school. I would say almost daily. We also have [an app] that we can go on and communicate with staff as well. So, and with my child we have a communication book that goes back and forth."
>
> *- Focus Group Participant, Oxford County Parent*

> "I want to be involved in all aspects. I get frustrated with the school because I do communicate, but I often find them unresponsive. When I seek support for my child through the school, I need to really push to make it happen. This includes the school not adequately following a 504 plan."
>
> *- Penobscot County Parent*

> "I have seen, especially around the holidays, the schools do activities to bring the parents in and stuff like that magic nights, Halloween night where they did pumpkins and stuff. So I've seen definitely, you know, things to involve us and spring fairs and stuff. So it's really good in our community."
>
> *- Focus Group Participant, Penobscot County Parent*

Bright Spots

- Strong relationships with individual teachers were praised across schools.
- Families highlighted the power of regular, respectful communication.

Opportunities for Growth

- Build schoolwide practices rooted in inclusion and responsiveness.
- Reduce communication silos and empower more staff to engage directly with families.

Staffing Roles and Relationships

Nearly one in five families said having direct contact at the school would make a difference. This was especially important for families balancing multiple jobs or those unfamiliar with the school system.

> "I would love more communication about how my child is doing socially/emotionally on a regular basis, so I know how best to support them at home and communicate with my child about specifics, if they've had difficulties or positive interactions at school."
>
> *- York County Parent*

Staff roles and responsibilities are often unclear to families, creating barriers to effective engagement. Clarity in staffing roles and consistent outreach could go a long way. This aligns with broader survey trends. While many families reported receiving help from staff, fewer families of color said they received support in understanding their child's needs, suggesting equity gaps in how school-staff relationships are experienced (see *Equity Spotlight*).

Bright Spots

- Families clearly articulated what would help them engage.
- Some already have strong relationships with specific staff.

Opportunities for Growth

- Clarify and communicate staff roles more proactively.
- Assign designated contacts to families to foster consistent engagement.

Supporting Academic Engagement

Many families want to help their children with academics, but don't feel equipped. Common requests included video tutorials, explanations of the curriculum, and take-home materials. These

needs were particularly common among those who cited time or lack of knowledge as barriers.

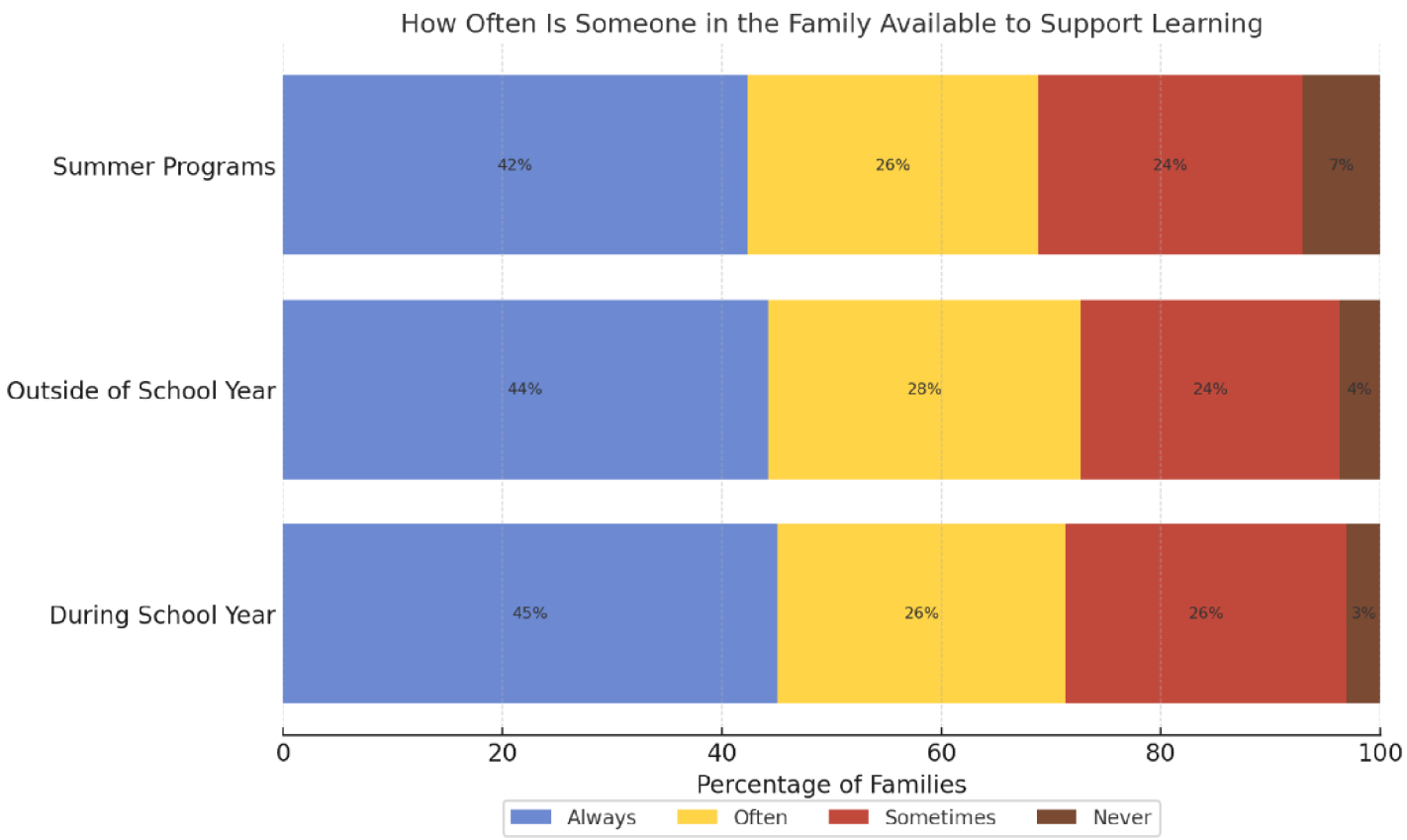
Bright Spots

- Families are eager to help and want tools to do so.
- Families value transparency and proactive communication.

Opportunities for Growth

- Provide accessible, parent-friendly curricular information.
- Offer regular opportunities for parents to learn how to support instruction.

Promising Practices



What's Working and Why It Matters

Despite obstacles, families are making meaningful strides:

- 46% of families reported no barriers to accessing learning support
- 60% said schools help with enrichment
- Nearly half had someone always available to support learning across the school year and summer
  - Roughly 45%-47% of families reported they are always available to support their child's learning; during school, after school, and in summer, highlighting family willingness as a critical strength.

> *"We work really hard to have a lot of translated materials..They have like 5 versions of the same flyer because it's all in all different languages. So that's really, I feel like that's helpful...I haven't been to parent group in a long time, but we used to make sure that, like we were getting, we were using some of our funds like if there were shopping like opportunities for that cost money that we were making sure that everyone had access to them even if they didn't have the money to do them."*
>
> *- Focus Group Participant, Cumberland County Parent*

Bright Spots

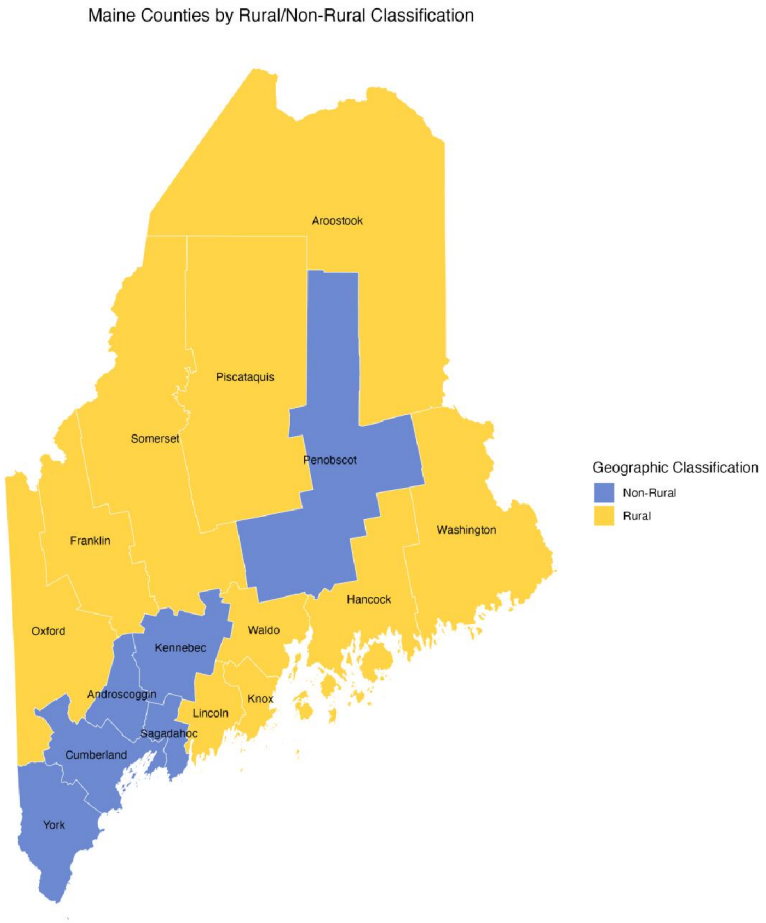
- Families are deeply committed and making learning work despite barriers.
- Schools already support enrichment for many families.

Opportunities for Growth

- Scale these bright spots by learning what's working.

- Improve communication timelines, so families can plan ahead.

Equity Spotlight

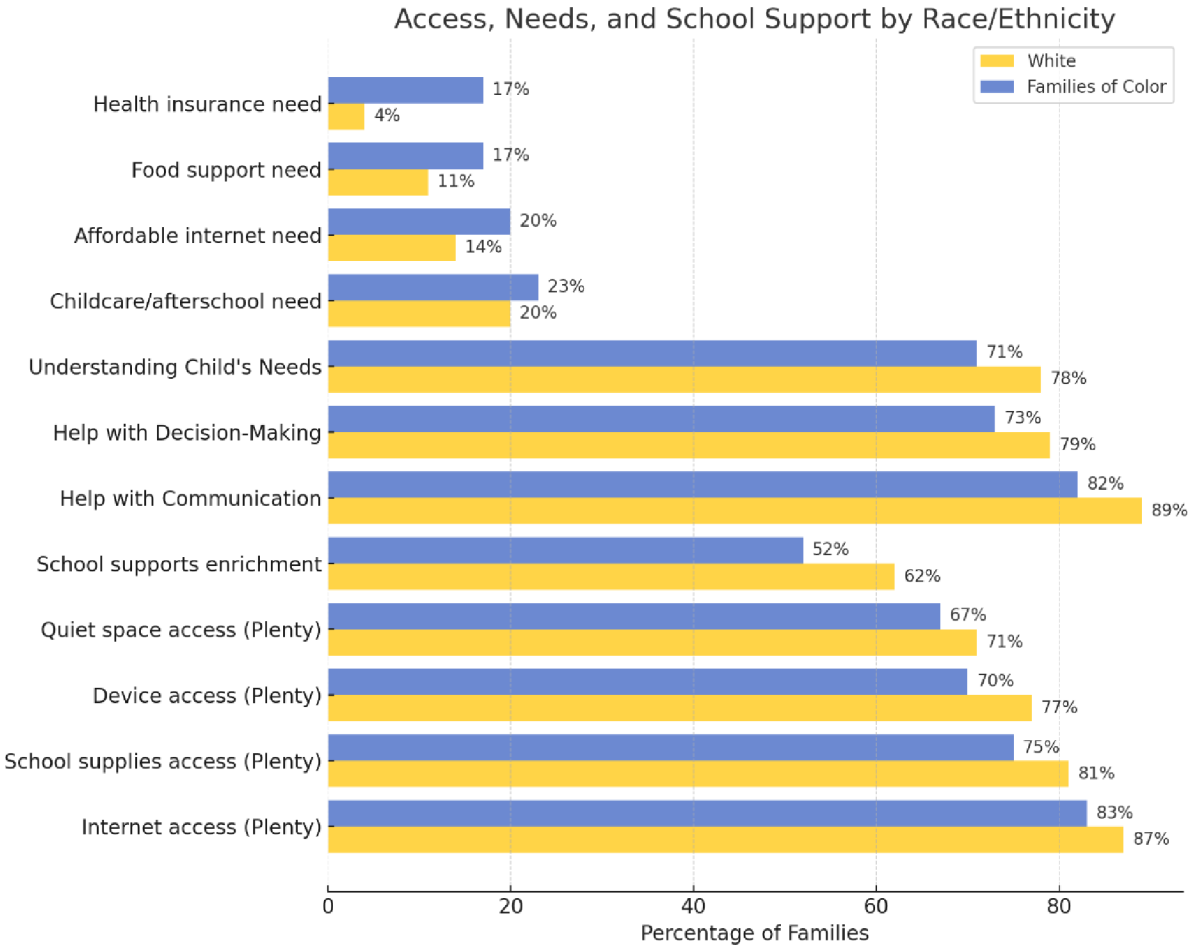


The survey explored learning access, enrichment, school communication, and support for basic needs. Approximately 62% of families had two adults in the household. Among them, 36% had one to two children and 14% had three or more. This provides helpful context on how household structures influence capacity for learning support. Because 91% of respondents spoke English at home, the data was not disaggregated by language. Instead, responses were analyzed by:

- **Race:** White families and families of color.

- **Geography:** Rural and non-rural (based on federal county designations)
  - **Rural Counties:** Aroostook, Franklin, Hancock, Knox, Lincoln, Oxford, Piscataquis, Somerset, Waldo, and Washington.
  - **Non-Rural Counties:** Androscoggin, Cumberland, Kennebec, Penobscot, Sagadahoc, and York.

This triangulation of data offers both a statewide overview and a closer look at equity gaps.



Disparities by Race and Ethnicity: White and Families of Color

Families of color consistently reported less access, fewer supports, and higher barriers compared to White families.

Learning Support

63% of White families said their school provides learning resources compared to 60% of families of color.

While this gap is smaller than in other areas, it still reflects uneven access to foundational supports that shapes a child's academic journey.

Family Perceptions of Staff Support

White families were more likely to report receiving support from school staff in key relational domains:

- 89% received help with communication compared to 82% of families of color.
- 79% received help with decision-making compared to 73% of families of color.
- 78% received help with understanding their child's needs compared to 71% of families of color.

These differences suggest that families of color may experience less support or different kinds of interactions when navigating schools. Building equitable family engagement requires not just the availability of services but also inclusive, affirming relationships.

Enrichment Access

Families of color were less likely to report that their school supports enrichment, with 52% saying so compared to 62% of White families.

Families of color were also more likely to report barriers to enrichment:

- 20% reported a lack of transportation compared to 15% of White families.
- 32% reported not knowing how to sign up compared to 23% of White families.

- 32% reported not knowing who to contact compared to 27% of White families.

These gaps point to communication and access challenges that disproportionately affect families of color.

Basic Needs

Families of color also expressed higher needs across nearly all support areas:

- 17% expressed a need for food support compared to 11% of White families.
- 17% expressed a need for health insurance compared to 4% of White families.
- 20% expressed a need for affordable internet compared to 14% of White families.
- 23% expressed a need for childcare or afterschool programs compared to 20% of White families.

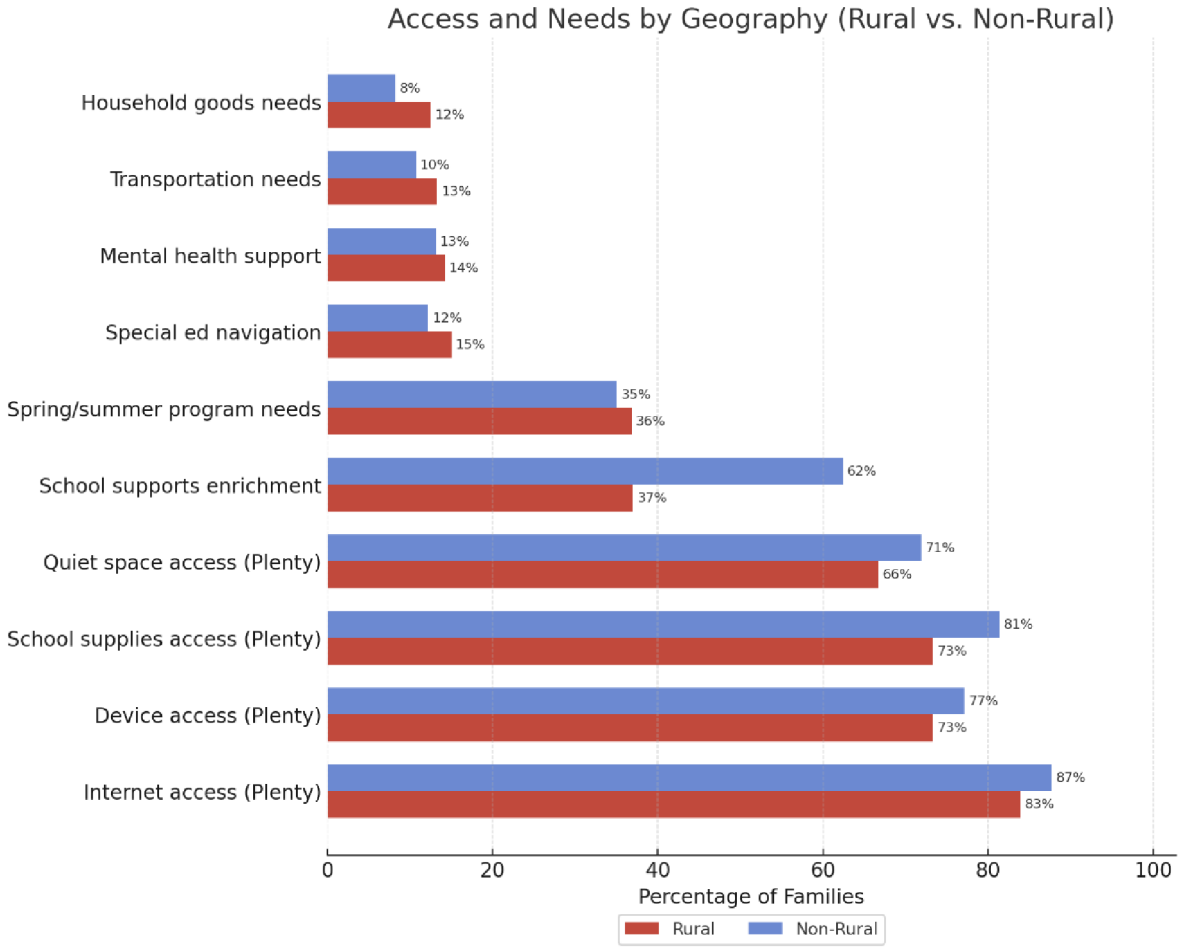
These disparities reflect long-standing structural inequities and underscore the need for systemic, not situational, responses.

Bright Spots

- The survey sample allowed for meaningful racial disaggregation.
- Needs voiced by families of color were clearly and consistently expressed across topics.

Opportunities for Growth

- Invest in culturally responsive materials, communication, and practices.
- Prioritize supports for mental health, food access, housing, and internet equity in school improvement plans.



Disparities by Geography: Rural vs. Non-Rural

Families in rural areas consistently reported lower access to enrichment, more frequent infrastructure challenges, and greater uncertainty about school-based supports.

Enrichment Access

Only 37% of rural families said their school supports enrichment, compared to 62% of non-rural families.

This substantial gap suggests that access to supplemental learning opportunities is limited by geography and may also reflect differences in program availability or communication.

Digital and Learning Resources

Rural families reported greater challenges in meeting basic digital and learning needs. Compared to their non-rural peers, they were

more likely to say they had limited or no access to essential resources:

- Electronic devices: 26.7% of rural families said they had *some or no access*, compared to 22.9% of non-rural families
- Internet: 16.1% of rural families reported *some or no access*, vs. 12.3% of non-rural families
- Quiet space for learning: 33.3% of rural families had *limited or no access*, compared to 28.1% of non-rural families
- School supplies: 26.7% of rural families said they had *some or no access*, vs. 18.6% of non-rural families

Sometimes small infrastructure gaps in rural areas where connectivity, space, and access to supplies may be harder to secure can compound over time, especially when paired with the limited awareness of existing programs.

Non-Academic Needs

Rural families were also more likely to request support for:

- Transportation (13%)
- Household goods (13%)
- Mental health services (14%)
- Special education navigation (15%)
- Spring/summer programs (37%)

These needs reflect the logistical and geographic realities that shape everyday access for rural families.

Bright Spots

- Rural families contributed detailed insights that highlighted often-overlooked structural and logistical barriers.
- Their responses underscore the need for localized solutions, as in not one-size-fits-all; approaches should reflect rural families' unique challenges (like transportation, digital access, or small

school staffing). Custom strategies that work in their specific communities should be implemented..

Opportunities for Growth

- Tailor outreach to rural schedules, transportation realities, and digital infrastructure.
- Invest in stronger communication systems that make opportunities easier to understand and access.

Community Recommendations and Call to Action

To create more equitable, family-centered systems, we recommend the following actions:

Clarify and Expand Communication

Ensure families know what resources exist, how to access them, and when they're available.

Improve Navigation for Enrichment

Use centralized platforms, plain language, and longer lead times for programs.

Address Whole-Family Needs

Partner with local organizations to meet food, housing, mental health, and childcare needs.

Disaggregate and Act on Data

Use race- and region-specific insights to drive equity-centered decisions.

Celebrate and Scale What Works

Document and replicate successful programs and relationships already working in the field.

Action

Families across Maine are ready and willing to partner in education. They bring valuable insights, deep commitment, and a strong understanding of their children's needs. Yet, navigating complex systems can be especially difficult for those with the fewest resources and supports.

This report offers both guidance and an opportunity for shared growth.

For districts across Maine, the question is shifting from "Are families ready to engage?" to "Are we creating the conditions that truly support and welcome family partnership?"

This work doesn't rest on schools and districts alone. Community-based organizations, health partners, and family support networks each have an important role in creating systems that are responsive, inclusive, and built with families in mind.

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Disclaimer

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Centering Family Voices Across Maine's Public Schools

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